I am Waiting and Overpopulation

By Lawrence Ferlinghetti

INTRODUCTION

One of the beat poets, Lawrence Ferlinghetti captures an alternative perspective on life in postwar America in his poem I Am Waiting. Ferlinghetti's vision has much to teach Americans about themselves, their flaws, and their potential. It reflects the poet's critique of the status quo in many areas: civil rights, a disapproval of social snobbery, and disdain for those who would use tradition as an excuse for oppression.

I Am Waiting

I am waiting for my case to come up

and I am waiting

for a rebirth of wonder

and I am waiting for someone

to really discover America

and wail

and I am waiting

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for the discovery

Of a new symbolic western frontier

and I am waiting

for the American Eagle

to really spread its wings

and straighten up and fly right

and I am waiting for the Age of Anxiety

to drop dead

and I am waiting

for the war to be fought

which will make the world safe

for anarchy

and I am waiting for the final withering away

of all governments

and I am perpetually awaiting

a rebirth of wonder

I am waiting for the second coming

And I am waiting

For a religious revival

To sweep thru the state of Arizona

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And I am waiting
For the grapes of wrath to stored
And I am waiting
For them to prove
That God is really American
And I am waiting
To see God on television
Piped into church altars
If they can find
The right channel
To tune it in on
And I am waiting
for the last supper to be served again
and a strange new appetizer
and I am perpetually awaiting
a rebirth of wonder

I am waiting for my number to be called
and I am waiting
for the Salvation Army to take over
and I am waiting

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for the meek to be blessed
and inherit the earth
without taxes
and I am waiting
for forests and animals
to reclaim the earth as theirs
and I am waiting
for a way to be devised
to destroy all nationalisms
without killing anybody
and I am waiting
for linnets and planets to fall like rain
and I am waiting for lovers and weepers
to lie down together again
in a new rebirth of wonder

I am waiting for the great divide to be crossed
and I am anxiously waiting
For the secret of eternal life to be discovered
By an obscure practitioner
and I am waiting

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for the storms of life
to be over
and I am waiting to set sail for happiness
and I am waiting
for a reconstructed Mayflower
to reach America
with its picture story and TV rights
sold in advance to the natives
and I am waiting
for the lost music to sound again
in the Lost Continent
in a new rebirth of wonder

I am waiting for the day
that maketh all things clear
and I am waiting for retribution
for what America did to Tom Sawyer
and I am waiting
for the American Boy
to take off Beauty's clothes
and I am waiting

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for Alice in Wonderland
to retransmit to me
her total dream of innocence
and I am waiting
for Childe Roland to come
to the final darkest tower
and I am waiting for Aphrodite
to grow live arms
at a final disarmament conference
in a new rebirth of wonder

I am waiting
to get some intimations
of immortality
by recollecting my early childhood
and I am waiting
for the green mornings to come again
for some strains of unpremeditated art
to shake my typewriter
and I am waiting to write
the great indelible poem

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and I am waiting

for the last long rapture

and I am perpetually waiting

for the fleeting lovers on the Grecian Urn

to catch each other at last

and embrace

and I am awaiting

perpetually and forever

a renaissance of wonder

TRANSITION

Another social concern that affects everyone on our planet and is probably the one problem behind all the other crises on earth right now is overpopulation. You could take any daily newspaper and stories could be traced back to some overpopulation cause. For instance, why do loggers want to cut down rain forests? Because people need more houses. Why do they need more houses? Because there's a huge increase in population worldwide. Overpopulation by Lawrence Ferlinghetti.

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OVERPOPULATION

I must have misunderstood something

In this story

There must be a misprint

In this paper

Hats off! It says here

The final war is over

Again

Here they come again

Parading by

The café terrace

I stand on my chair to see

I still can't see

The brave burned hero's face

I stand on the table

Waving my only hat

With the hole in it

I throw the hole away

Into the street

After the black limousine

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I don't throw my paper
I sit down with my paper
Which has the explanation of everything
Except there's a hole in it
Something missing in the story
Where the hole is
Or I must have misunderstood something
The nations have decided
It says here
To abolish themselves at last
It's been decided at the highest level
And at the lowest level
To return to a primitive society
For science has conquered nature
But nature must not be conquered
So science must be abolished
And machines must go
After all their turning and turning
The automobile is a passing thing
After all
The horse is here to stay

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Population has reached its limit
There's standing room only
Nowhere
To lie down
Anymore
Medicine must be abolished
So people can die
When they're supposed to
There's still room
Under the surface
I keep hoping
I have misunderstood something
In this story
People still lose
And find themselves
In bed
And animals still
Aren't as cruel as people
Because they can't talk
But we weren't designed
To live forever and ever

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And design is everything
The little enzyme they've discovered
That causes aging
Must be lost in the body again
All must be begun over
In a new pastoral era
There've been too many advances
Life can't bear it
Any longer
Life is not a drug
Made from mushrooms
Eaten by Samoyeds in Siberia
Which fully retain
Their intoxicating properties
When transmitted in urine
So that an endless line of men
May get drunk over and over
On the same mushroom
I must have misunderstood something
In this story
Life is intoxicating

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But can't go on and on
Putting on more and more
Complicated clothes
Hats girdles garter belts
Uplift bras lifting higher and higher
Until they fly away
And breasts fall
After all
We've got to get naked again
It says here
Though fornication's still illegal
In certain states
I must have misunderstood something
In this story
The world's no Klee mobile
And there must be an end
To all this rotation
Around the goofball sun
The sun in its [sic] transit
Barely clears the rooftops now
Bumps over a Mobilgas Pegasus

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And sinks behind my paper

With its hole

In which I keep hoping

I've misunderstood something

For death is not the answer

To our problem

There must be some mistake –

There is –

The editorials say

We must do something

And we cannot do anything

For something's missing

Where the hole is

Sitting on the terrace

Of this fancy coffeehouse

On the left side of the world

Where I must have misunderstood something

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lawrence Ferlinghetti
Book: A Coney Island of the Mind
ISBN: 978-0811200417
Publisher: New Directions Publishing
Date (Month/Year): Oct 1974

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier

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